

SELF-LOADING RIFLES

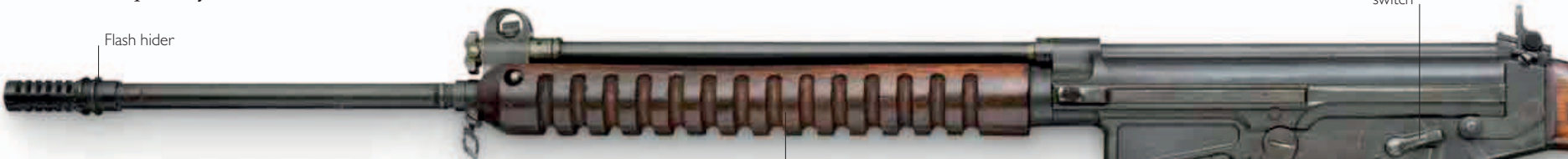
Drawing upon the designs developed during World War II, and the performance of the arms made during that conflict, postwar designers further refined self-loading rifles. Improvements were made to their locks, or actions, synthetic materials began to replace wood stocks, and pressed metal components were introduced to reduce weight. Importantly, most of these rifles, which were all gas-operated (including those featured here), were chambered for standardized cartridges adopted by defense unions, such as NATO.



▲ SIMONOV SKS-45 CARBINE

Date	1945
Origin	Soviet Union
Barrel	20½in (52cm)
Caliber	7.62 × 39mm

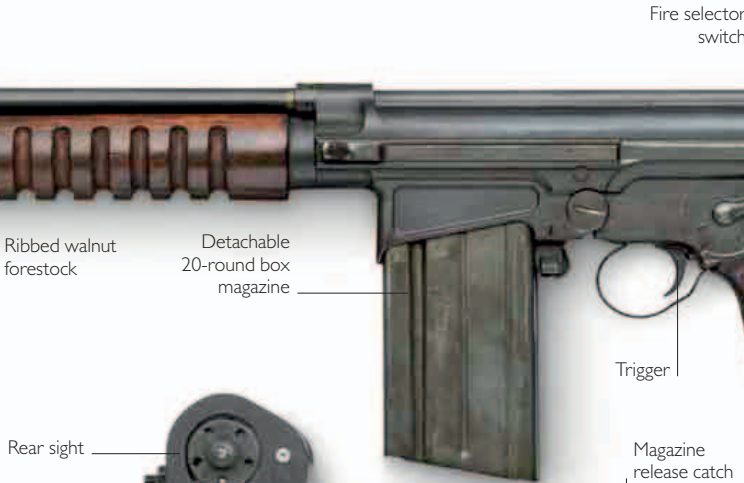
Designed by Sergei Gravitovich Simonov, the SKS entered service in 1945, and variants have been sold throughout the world. It was adopted as China's primary battle rifle. Some variants, such as this example, were equipped with permanently attached bayonets that folded rearward when not in use.



▲ FN FAL PROTOTYPE

Date	1950
Origin	Belgium
Barrel	23½in (60cm)
Caliber	.280in

Originally developed to fire a .280in caliber cartridge, the FAL proved to be an immediate success. It was later modified for use with the 7.62 × 51mm NATO round, which was developed as a standard for small arms among NATO countries. This rifle has seen service throughout the world.



▼ L1A1

Date	1954
Origin	UK
Barrel	21in (53.3cm)
Caliber	7.62 × 51mm NATO

The L1A1, manufactured by the Royal Small Arms Factory, Enfield, UK, was the standard British service rifle until its replacement by the L85A1 (see p.250) in 1985. It was adapted from the Belgian FN FAL (above), but with minor changes to the specifications, to facilitate manufacture in the UK.

